



Nature for Resilient Infrastructure:

Grant Support for Sustainable Infrastructure through Nature-Based Solutions in Central Asia

Nature-Based Solutions Innovation Accelerator (NBS-IA)

Open Call for Proposals Framework Document

2 April 2026

Contents

1.	Background	2
2.	Regional Context in Central Asia	2
3.	Objectives	3
4.	Scope and Typology	3
4.1	Geographic Scope	3
4.2	Eligible Typologies	3
4.3	Eligible Sectors	5
4.4	Examples of Eligible Activities	6
5.	Eligibility Criteria and Selection Process	7
5.1	Eligibility Screening:	8
5.2	Proposal Assessment:	9
5.3	Shortlisting and Due Diligence	12
5.4	Grant Award Decision	12
6.	Application Process and Timeline	12
7.	Grant Award and Reporting	13
8.	Data Protection	13
9.	Questions and Requests for Clarification	13
	Annex 1: Eligible and Ineligible Costs	14
	Annex 2: Suggested set of indicators for Monitoring, Reporting and Verification (MRV)	15

1. Background

Infrastructure forms the backbone of economies by providing essential services such as transportation, energy, and water. However, it remains highly vulnerable to natural disasters as climate risks intensify. It is estimated that 14% of global GDP growth is at risk annually due to loss of infrastructure services from climate-related events, with populations in developing countries facing heightened vulnerability. The World Bank projects that between USD 57 and 95 trillion in infrastructure will be built worldwide by 2030. To prevent locking in future vulnerabilities and to enhance the resilience of existing infrastructure, smarter policies, planning, design, and investments are imperative to boost the integration of Nature-based Solutions (NbS)¹ into infrastructure development.

NbS offer vital responses to multiple climate-related challenges across urban and natural environments by mitigating the impacts of extreme heat, flooding, drought, landslides, soil erosion, and air pollution. Numerous studies conclude that NbS can often be more cost effective than grey infrastructure solutions in delivering services than grey infrastructure solutions, and provide additional economic, environmental, and social benefits. The examples include long-term performance appreciation, potential economic savings from climate-related hazards, increased biodiversity and ecosystem resilience, and improved human well-being and quality of life. This holistic approach positions NbS as a strategic component of sustainable, resilient, and adaptive infrastructure development.

In response to the urgent need to increase climate resilience and integrate NbS into existing and new infrastructure, the Italian Ministry of Environment and Energy Security (IMEES/MASE), in collaboration with the United Nations Environment Programme (UNEP) and the Organization for Economic Co-operation (OECD), launched the Nature-based Solutions Innovation Accelerator (NBS-IA). This 5-year initiative aims to accelerate the uptake of NbS approaches to enhance infrastructure resilience in both Central Asia and Africa. Through competitive calls for proposals, the initiative provides grant support to consortia that present innovative pilot projects that can demonstrate the highest climate adaptation impact and financial and operational viability.

2. Regional Context in Central Asia

Central Asia faces acute climate vulnerabilities due to its reliance on glacier-fed rivers and water-scarce drylands, with accelerating warming, glacier retreat, and diminishing snowpack already cutting late-season flows essential for irrigation, hydropower, and livelihoods. The region is experiencing above-average global warming, driving elevation-dependent glacier loss in the Tian Shan and Pamirs mountains, reducing summer water availability and heightening risks of droughts, floods, and glacial-lake outburst floods².

Since these climate impacts are already disrupting water supplies, logistics networks, and energy infrastructure, the region urgently needs resilience-focused infrastructure to reduce risk and safeguard development gains. [UNECE Environmental Performance Reviews](#), as well as their national climate and development frameworks including Nationally Determined Contributions (NDCs) and National Adaptation Plans (NAPs) and green economy strategies, reiterate the urgent

¹ Actions aimed at protecting, conserving, restoring, and sustainably managing natural or modified terrestrial, freshwater, coastal, and marine ecosystems, which address social, economic and environmental challenges effectively and adaptively, while simultaneously providing human well-being, ecosystem services, resilience and biodiversity benefits (UNEA 5.2)

² IPCC, 2023: Climate Change 2023: Synthesis Report.

need to accelerate climate adaptation efforts, leveraging NbS, in vulnerable sectors like water resources, energy, agriculture, health, and ecosystems.

Conventional grey infrastructure alone is often insufficient or cost-prohibitive to address these evolving risks under future climate scenarios. Integrating natural infrastructure and NbS with grey infrastructure offers a promising pathway to enhance climate adaptation outcomes by reducing hazard intensity, improving asset performance, extending infrastructure lifespans, and delivering additional social and environmental co-benefits.

3. Objectives

This Call for Proposals seeks to support the integration of NbS in grey infrastructure that demonstrate clear and measurable climate adaptation impacts, generate practical implementation evidence, and create pathways for scaling and replication across Central Asia.

The overall objective of this Call is to **enhance the climate resilience** of critical infrastructure systems in Central Asia through the design and piloting of NbS in grey infrastructure that produce demonstrable adaptation benefits. Specifically, the Call is looking for pilot projects that can:

- ✓ Reduce climate-related risks on infrastructure assets and services through NbS;
- ✓ Demonstrate the technical, financial, and institutional feasibility of sustainable infrastructure through NbS approaches in the Central Asian context;
- ✓ Generate measurable evidence, primarily on climate adaptation potential and other co-benefits, for instance, climate mitigation potential, contribution to addressing societal challenges, protecting biodiversity, etc. and demonstrate cost-effectiveness;
- ✓ Strengthen regional, national or local capacity for designing, piloting, and managing sustainable infrastructure through NbS;
- ✓ Support measuring impact (compared to Business as Usual).
- ✓ Identify replication and scalability potential.

4. Scope and Typology

4.1 Geographic Scope

This Call is open to proposals implemented in Central Asian countries, including:

Kazakhstan, Kyrgyz Republic, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan, and Uzbekistan.

4.2 Eligible Typologies

For the purpose of this Call, only interventions that apply NbS to enhance the resilience of either existing or future “grey” infrastructure are eligible. Each proposal must explicitly identify the target grey asset, the relevant climate hazard, the causal mechanism by which the NbS reduces risk/exposure/vulnerability, the infrastructure service protected or improved, and the baseline/business-as-usual scenario.

These types of interventions are infrastructure systems that combine natural or nature-based components with engineered or grey infrastructure to deliver infrastructure services and reduce risks. For example, riparian afforestation and wetlands can work together with built

infrastructure (such as river embankments, and downstream hydropower facilities) to provide enhanced infrastructure services that protect from floods, droughts, and dust storms.

This Call for Proposals can provide two types of grants: **1) Design Grant** and **2) Pilot Grant**. Under Pilot Grant, two types of interventions are eligible: *Type A) NbS centred pilot interventions*, and *Type B) Hybrid NbS pilot interventions*, as defined below. Proposals must be focused on protecting and enhancing infrastructure service delivery or improving the climate resilience of existing or planned grey infrastructure.

Please note that standalone NbS projects that are not linked to grey infrastructure are NOT eligible. For example, rainwater harvesting projects, sustainable agriculture projects, ecosystem restoration projects that do not have any interaction with any grey infrastructure, in terms of protection, enhancement and/or operability. Pure research projects are also not eligible.

1) Design Grant

Proposals submitted under the Design Grant window should focus on the design, feasibility and preparation activities of integrating potential NbS interventions into grey infrastructure. Identification of innovative solutions are encouraged, including concepts at early-stage development. Design and preparation study must be linked to the preparation of a particular intervention on the ground. Pure research studies are not eligible.

The maximum amount for Design Grant is US\$300,000.

2) Pilot Grant

Proposals submitted under the Pilot Grant window must include pilot interventions on the ground. Design and preparation studies could also be included with a budget up to US\$ 300,000. For Pilot Grants, a minimum readiness threshold is required. Proposals must demonstrate, via a readiness matrix, that the site is identified, the asset owner/operator is involved, a preliminary hazard diagnosis is available, land/access status is clarified, environmental/social risks are preliminarily screened, an O&M entity is identified, and public authority engagement is evidenced.

Type A: NbS centred pilot interventions

NbS centred pilots are interventions in which the proposed solution relies exclusively on natural or ecosystem-based processes (e.g. vegetation, soils, wetlands, water bodies) to protect or enhance service delivery by grey infrastructure. These interventions do not include altering the original design or role of any grey infrastructure components.

For example, native forest restoration in upstream mountain catchments supports downstream hydropower through landslide mitigation, while watershed and riverside restoration improve water supply, and vegetated roadside buffers control erosion and dust storms. Agroforestry corridors and green walls along energy transmission/distribution lines reduce flooding and soil erosion. Urban green corridors mitigate flood risks and urban heat-island effects.

The budget for Type A pilot grant is between US\$ 500,000 – US\$ 1,000,000 (including design and preparation studies if needed). Budget of this type of proposals **should not** include any cost for grey components.

Type B: Hybrid NbS pilot interventions

Hybrid NbS pilots combine Nature-based Solutions with existing or planned engineered or grey infrastructure components. Nature-based elements are either physically integrated into grey infrastructure assets to enhance performance and climate resilience (e.g. riparian bioswales/vegetate buffers integrated to roads, tree shelterbelts integrated to canals/roads, green roofs and rain gardens integrated in urban buildings), or green and grey components function as distinct but coordinated elements that jointly reduce climate risk (e.g. riparian afforestation + river embankments).

The budget for Type B pilot is between US\$ 1,000,000 – US\$ 1,500,000 (including design and preparation studies if needed). This type of proposals could include a budget of **maximum of 20%**³ of the piloting grant amount (excluding design studies) on grey components⁴.

4.3 Eligible Sectors

This call supports design and pilot projects in the energy, water, transport, and urban and building sectors in Central Asia. Table 1 below lists some example NbS Interventions in these sectors. **The list of interventions are indicative and non-exhaustive, innovative solutions are highly encouraged, including concepts at early-stage development, and interventions that are not listed in Table 1.**⁵

Table 1. Eligible Sectors and example NbS Interventions (non-exhaustive)

Sector	Sub-Sector	NbS intervention examples
Energy⁶	- Hydroelectric Generation - Solar Power Generation - Wind Power Generation - Electricity Transmission and Distribution Network and substation	• Hydroelectric Generation: Upstream watershed conservation and natural ecosystem restoration for improved water resources management • Solar/Wind Power Generation: Pairing renewable energy technologies with green infrastructure and natural vegetation for energy efficiency, heat stress management, and erosion and flood risk control. • Electricity Transmission/Distribution Network: Agroforestry corridors and green walls to reduce flooding and soil erosion, protection from wildfire, and heat stress management.

³ For example, if a proposal is requesting an overall grant amount of 1,300,000 from NBS-IA, including 300,000 design study. The maximum budget that could be spent on grey component is: 20%*(1,300,000-300,000) =200,000.

⁴ “Grey components” include enabling works, anchoring systems, drainage adjustments, monitoring hardware and protective edge structures, while excluding heavy civil works that alter the primary structural integrity of an asset.

⁵ Applicants may leverage existing tools such as [IUCN Standards and the Online Self-Assessment Tool](#), and its 8 criteria for designing impactful NbS.

⁶ NBS-IA cannot support interventions that extend the lifetime or capacity of fossil -fuel power plants. However, support can be provided to using NBS to address legacy impacts or to facilitate a just and Paris-aligned transition, with clear demonstration on resilience building, pollution reduction and avoiding lock-in.

Water	- Potable Water Treatment - Industrial Water Treatment - Residential Wastewater Treatment & Reuse - Industrial Wastewater Treatment & Reuse - Water and sewerage networks - River Basin Management	• Potable/Industrial Water Treatment: Wetland restoration, river basin protection, agroforestry for infiltration, erosion/flood risk management, effluent polishing • River Basin Management: Riparian afforestation alongside river embankments; Watershed and riverside restoration to reduce flooding and soil erosion, and better water supply
Transport	- Long-distance Rail Lines - Urban Distribution Roads - Motorways	• Afforestation, pasture restoration, roadside forests/vegetated buffers, wetlands, green corridors for flood risk management, soil stabilisation, dust-storm mitigation, heat stress management • Riparian bioswales/vegetated buffers integrated with roads • Tree shelterbelts integrated with roads/canals
Urban	- Groups of buildings, building complexes, neighbourhoods, public spaces (public, private, services, etc.)	• Integration of green infrastructure (e.g., green roofs, rain gardens) for urban resilience, reduced stormwater runoff, and urban heat-island effects • Urban green corridors

Source: UNECE (2025), [Promoting Nature-based Solutions and Sustainable Infrastructure in the ECE Region: Environmental and Health Co-benefits](#); World Bank (2021), The Catalogue of Nature-based Solutions for Urban Resilience; Other experts' reviews

4.4 Examples of Eligible Activities

Below are some examples of eligible activities that can be funded by the grant support:

Design, feasibility assessments and preparation

- Climate vulnerability assessments and scenario analyses at the infrastructure asset level
- Identification of relevant societal challenges to address
- Relevant technical surveys and studies (e.g. Topographic and geotechnical surveys, hydraulic studies, land suitability survey, infiltration and groundwater recharge modelling, etc.)
- Standardised cost-benefit analysis using a minimum comparative matrix (baseline without project, grey-only alternative where relevant, NbS/hybrid option, CAPEX, OPEX/maintenance, lifespan assumptions, avoided damage/disruption, and co-benefits)
- Cost estimates and an investment plan for implementation, including potentially relevant revenue streams (e.g., carbon credits) and potential avoided costs
- Stakeholder mapping, consultations and action plans (including Indigenous Peoples and Local Communities and vulnerable groups)

- Development of project-level ESAP (Environmental and Social Action Plan) and Gender Analysis and Action Plan in line with the [IFC Performance Standards](#).

Small-scale project piloting

- Site selection and ground truthing
- Small-scale pilot project to test the selected NbS for the target infrastructure
- Site specific testing of selected interventions on their adaptation and hazard reduction potential
- Defining measurable KPIs and methods for baseline data collection to track environmental, social, and economic benefits, and alignment with national priorities, objectives and strategies
- Integration checks (interfaces between green and grey components)
- Engagement with local authorities, communities and users
- Construction or installation of green or hybrid infrastructure (e.g. planting, soil preparation, habitat creation, earthworks, hydrological and engineering works, and where relevant, integration with supporting grey infrastructure in the case of Hybrid NbS approaches)
- Establishment, maintenance, and adaptive management of green components, including biomaterials
- Development of a mandatory post-grant sustainability plan identifying the owner/operator, O&M responsibilities, annual O&M cost estimates, funding sources for maintenance, post-completion monitoring period, and triggers for corrective action

5. Eligibility Criteria and Selection Process

All applications will undergo a multistage screening and assessment process to ensure transparency and rigour in the selection and implementation of pilot projects, as outlined in Figure 1. Each stage is detailed in the following section.

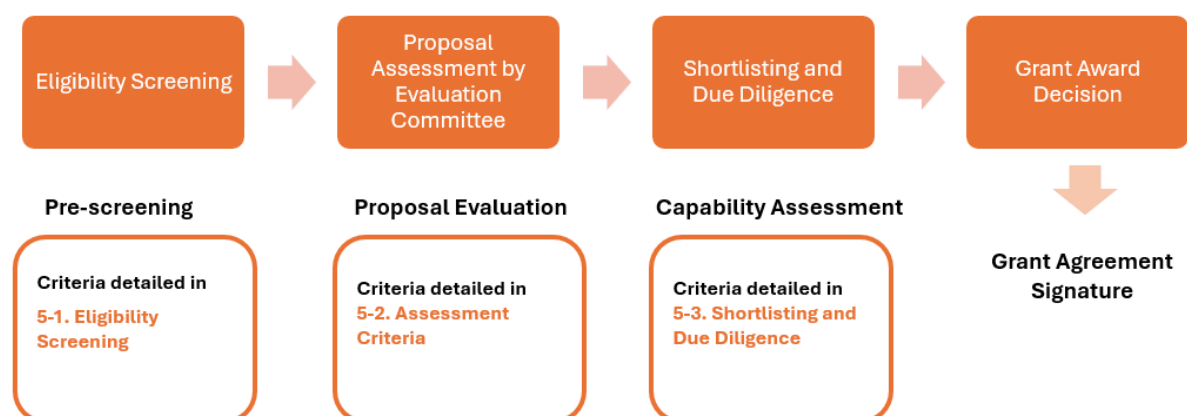


Figure 1. NBS-IA Selection Process

5.1 Eligibility Screening:

Applications will first be reviewed against the mandatory eligibility criteria outlined below, including geographic focus, NbS typology, target sectors, and other key elements, such as budget and consortium structure.

Geographic Focus: Kazakhstan, Kyrgyz Republic, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan, and Uzbekistan.

NbS Typologies: Proposed projects must demonstrate an innovative approach to integrating NbS into grey infrastructure in the target sector (energy, water, transport, urban & buildings), specify the type of grant support it is seeking and clearly articulate the anticipated adaptation outcome and other co-benefits, as well as the innovative components of the project. (See 4.2 Eligible Typologies for more details.)

Target Sectors: Design and pilot projects must be in the areas of energy, water, transport, and urban and building infrastructure in Central Asia. (See 4.3 Eligible Sectors for more details.)

Budget:

For **Design Grant** (both NbS centred and hybrid interventions), the maximum budget is **US\$ 300,000**.

For **Pilot Grant** (including design and preparation studies), budget should range from **US\$500,000 to US\$1,500,000** (excluding co-financing). For details, please refer to 4.2 Eligible Typologies and Table 2 below. Please also refer to Annex 1 for eligible costs (with maximum percentage limits), and ineligible costs.

Table 2. Grant amounts

Grant type	Proposal type	Grant Amount (USD)
Design Grant	Design and preparation studies	Up to 300,000
Pilot Grant	Pilot type A: NbS centered intervention	500,000 – 1,000,000
	Pilot type B: Hybrid intervention	1,000,000 – 1,500,000

Co-financing Requirements: Projects should include at least 30% co-financing⁷ from external sources, including in-kind contributions. Eligible in-kind contributions must be clearly valued and justified. The consortia have full discretion for resource allocation and distribution among the partners (not every consortium partner is expected to contribute with co-financing). Co-financing may come from various sources, including public and private sector partnerships, development finance institutions, and international donors.

Timeline:

Activities under **Design Grant** window must be completed within **24 months** from the project start date indicated on the contract.

Pilot projects awarded under the **Pilot Grant** window must be completed within **48 months** from the project start date indicated on the contract.

⁷ Co-financing percentage is based on the requested grant amount from NBS-IA. If the overall requested grant from NBS-IA is US\$ 1,000,000, the minimum co-finance required is 30%* 1,000,000=US\$300,000.

Consortium: Proposals must be submitted by a consortium that includes at least a private sector partner, a local partner, an international partner⁸, and any of the following: public/private organizations, NGOs, academia and/or research institutes.

It is encouraged to include International Financial Institutions, Multilateral Development Banks, and UN agencies to be part of the consortia, especially to provide co-financing, in-kind or technical support, however, they are not eligible to receive grant. Consortia should demonstrate adequate size, expertise, cost-effectiveness and gender representation⁹.

Proposals are encouraged to demonstrate synergies with existing and planned initiatives in the same location and/or sector by other institutions, including but not limited to government agencies, local organizations, Multilateral Development Banks, and international organizations.

Consortia must include organisations with substantial expertise in the following areas:

- Nature-based infrastructure and ecological engineering, landscape restoration and NbS, landscape architecture, hydrology, urban planning, etc.
- Infrastructure expertise in the target sector (energy, water, transport, urban and buildings)

To ensure operational substance, the consortium is encouraged to cover five key functions: infrastructure owner/operator interface, NbS/ecology lead, engineering/design lead, local implementation/community interface, and finance/fiduciary/procurement lead, with the understanding that one entity may tick multiple functions.

Consortia must submit a letter or MoU signed by each member indicating intent to collaborate, clear roles and responsibilities, and demonstrating a high level of local content or presence. However, **one entity must be designated as the consortium lead**.

The **consortium lead** will:

- Be responsible for all official communication during the application process and project implementation.
- If selected, **be the sole signatory to the grant contract** on behalf of the consortium.
- Bear fiduciary responsibility, coordinate deliverables, and ensure compliance with all contractual obligations including reporting on cofinancing¹⁰.

Eligible and Ineligible Costs: A List of eligible and ineligible costs with corresponding maximum percentage limits is provided in Annex 1.

5.2 Proposal Assessment:

Eligible applications will be reviewed by an independent Evaluation Committee composed of international subject-matter experts in NbS infrastructure, resilient infrastructure, climate adaptation, and alignment with the UN SDGs. The committee will score the applications based on the criteria outlined below (Assessment criteria).

⁸ An organization or company can cover more than one category (e.g. a local or international partner can be a private company).

⁹ The applications from consortia with more than 30% of female representation will be given higher score during the proposal assessment stage.

¹⁰ Cofinancing can be provided by any of, a part of, or the members of the consortium. Cofinancing may also be provided by members of the consortium who are not eligible to receive funds.

To avoid excessive dispersion and improve comparability, proposals will be assessed within sectoral sub-clusters (e.g., water, energy, transport, urban/buildings). Prioritisation will be given to projects demonstrating high asset criticality, strong demonstrative value and clear replicability within their sector.

Assessment Criteria

5-2-1. Potential for Transformational Impact and Sustainability through Innovation (40%)

Proposals must clearly demonstrate the potential of the planned intervention to enhance climate resilience and sustainability of infrastructure assets through Nature-based Solutions. Key considerations include:

- **Adaptation Outcomes:** Proposals must demonstrate how the proposed intervention reduces the current and future climate risks (including identified risks and how the intervention will reduce the exposure or vulnerability of the target infrastructure to the identified climate risks), what are the roles of the green and grey components, what are the expected adaptation outcomes and how will the expected adaptation outcomes be measured.
- **Environmental, social and Economic Impact:** For example, improved ecosystem restoration status, greenhouse gas emission reduction potentials, health co-benefits, benefits to local communities, such as job creation, empowerment of women and youth, improved productivity and access to essential services, reduced maintenance costs, and potential avoided costs from impacts of climate-related hazards.
- **Alignment with national climate and development policies and frameworks, and the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs):** Climate and development frameworks such as National Determined Contributions (NDCs), National Adaptation Plans (NAPs), sectoral development plans; relevant recommendations included in the [UNECE Environmental Performance Reviews](#) and [UNECE report on NbS and sustainable infrastructure](#) whenever applicable; SDGs such as SDG 6 (Clean Water and Sanitation), 9 (Industry, Innovation, and Infrastructure), SDG 11 (Sustainable Cities and Communities), SDG 13 (Climate Action), SDG 14 (Life Below Water), SDG 15 (Life on Land).

Consortia are encouraged to seek for country endorsement demonstrating that the proposals align with national priorities, objectives and strategies at the application stage. Endorsement/no-objection letters will be required for shortlisted candidates before receiving grant financing. The letters should come from the competent national authority (e.g., Ministry of Environment, Infrastructure, or Planning, etc.) relevant to the project's sector and location. The letter should confirm no objection to the project's objectives and implementation site. Delays in obtaining endorsement may affect the final award decision.

- **Innovation:** Innovation is highly encouraged from proposals. Innovation is defined as technical, institutional, financial, delivery/governance, or evidence-based innovation. The solution does not need to be “new” in absolute terms but must produce demonstrable added value in the local context. This could include, but not limited to, innovative designs of NbS integration with grey infrastructure, the scale and scope of

integration, the use of technology, data, and materials, financial innovation as well as implementation arrangement.

5-2-2. Potential for Scalability, Replicability, and Additionality (30%)

Proposals should demonstrate the potential for scalability and replicability in similar contexts, as well as additionality. This includes:

- **Scalability:** Clear pathways for expanding the solution to different sites and assets, beyond the implementing country and or region.
- **Replicability:** Evidence that the solution can be adapted to other countries or regions with minimal modifications.
- **Additionality:** Proposals must explicitly demonstrate and justify why the project requires NBS-IA grant support and would not proceed under business-as-usual conditions or existing financing mechanisms, demonstrating true additionality of UNEP's intervention. Applicants may specify which form of additionality applies: financial (funding gap), risk (grant absorbs initial risk), technical (supports demonstration/validation), institutional (enables coordination or permitting), market (unlocks a replicable but not yet bankable model), others or a combination.

Proposals are encouraged to demonstrate synergies with existing or planned initiatives in the same location and/or sector by other institutions, including but not limited to government agencies, local organizations, multilateral development banks, and international organizations.

5-2-3. Technical Feasibility and Financial Viability (30%)

- **Technical Feasibility:** Proposals must present technically sound and practical scope for the planned activities, with clear objectives and credible NbS interventions to be applied. Consortia should clearly articulate the expertise that each partner brings to the project, especially on infrastructure development, nature-based solutions and climate adaptation. Proposals must comply with national policies, strategies, plans and objectives, local and national regulatory frameworks (including land ownership, access rights, when applicable) and demonstrate stakeholder buy-in. For Pilot Grants, applicants are encouraged to provide evidence of relevant technical expertise in related fields.
Financial Viability: The proposals should present a credible financial and investment plan at asset level, with resourcing options to implement the project. This includes presenting a clear and robust budget, co-financing commitments, and evidence of financial stability to avoid disruptions during implementation, to the extent that they're available at this stage. A standardised cost-effectiveness comparison is recommended, using a minimum matrix the without-project scenario, grey-only alternative (where relevant), and the proposed NbS/hybrid option across CAPEX, OPEX, lifespan, avoided damages, and co-benefits.
- **Monitoring, Reporting, and Verification (MRV):** Proposed KPIs to track environmental, economic, and social impact must be included in the proposals, with prime focus on climate adaptation. A core set of suggested indicators are provided in Annex 2,

distinguished by grant window as follows. KPIs can be revised during the feasibility study, but the core set must remain,

Each application will be scored on the above criteria, as well as gender-responsive consortia structure, and the highest-ranked proposals will be recommended for due diligence.

5.3 Shortlisting and Due Diligence

High-ranking applicants will be shortlisted and invited for due diligence to verify legal, financial, and technical feasibility, compliance, and readiness. This process may include requests for additional documentation, virtual meetings or site visits as needed. Should a proposal fail the due diligence assessment, the following highest-ranked proposal will be advanced instead.

UNEP will make the final funding decisions, considering the Evaluation Committee's recommendations and alignment with NBS-IA's objectives.

5.4 Grant Award Decision

Once due diligence is completed, grant agreements will be finalized with successful lead applicants.

- Successful Applicants: Announced publicly, followed by contract signing by lead applicants.
- Unsuccessful Applicants: Lead applicants shall be notified following grant signature for successful applicants. Feedback will not be provided at this stage.

6. Application Process and Timeline

Applications **must be submitted [online](#)** before the submission deadline at **23:59 CET on 30 June 2026** in **English**.

To prepare proposals, applicants can review and download the [application form](#), as well as the templates for [budget](#) and [logical frame](#).

Submission via email will not be accepted.

Launch of Call for Proposals	2 April 2026
Informational Webinar	2 April 2026
Proposal Submission Deadline	30 June 2026
Proposal Evaluation Period	1 July 2026 – 31 October 2026
Announcement and Project Start Date	Q4 2026 - Q1 2027

7. Grant Award and Reporting

Each selected consortia lead will sign a [grant agreement](#) with the NBS-IA's Implementing Partner. The agreed grant disbursement terms and schedule will be outlined in the agreement.

The selected consortia are required to submit bi-annual progress reports of their respective projects. It is also required to submit externally audited financial statements for the NBS-IA-funded project. The costs for such an audit could be included in the project budget. In addition, selected consortia will participate in monitoring activities, including site visits (as applicable), and communication and knowledge-sharing initiatives as deemed necessary by UNEP.

All selected consortia will adhere to [UNEP Prevention of Sexual Exploitation, Abuse and Harassment policies](#).

8. Data Protection

UNEP is fully committed to protecting personal data in line with the [UN System's Principles on Personal Data Protection and Privacy](#). Participants' rights—including access, rectification, and objection—are safeguarded, with security measures aligned to international standards like Regulation (EU) 2016/679 of the European Parliament and of the Council of 27 April 2016 on the protection of natural persons with regard to the processing of personal data and on the free movement of such data.

9. Questions and Requests for Clarification

Applicants who need clarification on any section of the application form or have questions about the application may contact the UNEP project team (nbs-ia@un.org), with specific inquiries. A list of FAQs will be available on the project's [webpage](#).

Annex 1: Eligible and Ineligible Costs

Eligible costs (Maximum Percentages, if applicable)

- Overhead (10% maximum)
- Project management (7% maximum)
- Hardware purchase (15% maximum)
- Grey component (20% maximum¹¹)
- Software costs (for permits, if any)
- NbS implementation costs
- Working hours
- Travel costs
- Meeting costs
- Communication
- External services (audit costs)
- Other eligible pre-operative expenses approved

Ineligible costs

- Land purchase
- Investments in individual companies
- Long-term maintenance and operation costs
- Independent freelance activities
- Writing applications
- Overtime costs
- Salary increases
- Indirect taxes and duties, including VAT
- “Return on capital employed”, including dividends and other distributions of profits
- Provisions for possible future losses and charges
- Costs related to any interests
- Provisions for doubtful debts
- Unnecessary or ill-considered expenses
- Marketing, sales and distribution costs for products and services
- Leasing costs (or part thereof) where the leasing arrangement has the effect of unnecessarily increasing the charge made to the project (e.g. where the cost without interest of the leased equipment is higher than if purchased).
- Political or religious activities, which fall outside the scope of proposals
- Retrospective financing (Costs incurred before project approval)

¹¹ Only eligible for Type B pilot projects. Maximum 20% of the pilot grant amount (excluding the cost of design studies and co-financing). Design studies and Type A pilot projects are ineligible for grey component.

Annex 2: Suggested set of indicators for Monitoring, Reporting and Verification (MRV)

A. Indicators suggested for all proposals (Design Grant and Pilot Grant)

Indicator	Description
Hazard addressed	Specific climate hazard (e.g., glacial lake outburst flood, dust storm, extreme heat, flash flood, drought, landslide, etc.)
Asset/service protected	Specific grey infrastructure asset or service (e.g., hydropower intake, road segment, building cooling system, water treatment plant, etc.)
Baseline exposure/vulnerability	Quantified current level of risk (e.g., days/year of disruption, m ³ /year sediment load, °C above threshold, etc.)
Expected adaptation benefit	Quantified reduction in risk post-intervention (e.g., 50% reduction in downtime, 30% reduction in sediment, etc.)
Direct beneficiaries/service users	Number and type of people or entities relying on protected infrastructure service (e.g., 50,000 residents, 200 farmers, one industrial facility, etc.)
Implementation readiness	Status of site identification, land access, permitting, and stakeholder buy-in, etc.

B. Additional indicators suggested for all Pilot Grants (Type A and Type B)

Indicator	Description
Avoided disruption / downtime	Estimated reduction in service interruption (e.g., hours/year of road closure, days/years of power generation loss, etc.)
Reduction in hazard exposure	Quantified decrease in specific hazard intensity (e.g., % reduction in peak flood flow, % reduction in wind speed/dust concentration, °C reduction in surface temperature, etc.)
Asset performance improvement	Measurable change in infrastructure functionality (e.g., % increase in water conveyance efficiency, % reduction in sediment load to intake, % reduction in road maintenance frequency, etc.)
Maintenance implications	Expected maintenance requirements for the NbS components and the grey infrastructure (e.g., hours/year, estimated annual cost, skilled personnel needed, etc.)
O&M responsibility	Identified entity or role responsible for post-project operation and maintenance (e.g., municipal water authority, road department, community-based organisation, etc.)
Monitoring horizon post-installation	Duration and frequency of monitoring after project completion, etc.

C. Additional Indicator suggested for Type B (Hybrid NbS Pilot Project) only

Indicator	Description
Share of performance attributable to green vs. grey alternative/business-as-usual	Estimated percentage contribution of the NbS component to the overall risk reduction or performance improvement compared to the grey alternative/business-as-usual.